would be recognized as free. However, if a woman had sexual relations with a slave, the punishment was straightforward: death.

Historical research on slavery in India over the past millennium has revealed its diverse forms in military service and domestic work, and in contrast with the Americas, some remarkable avenues available for upward mobility.[70] Richard Eaton, a distinguished historian of medieval India, defines slavery in this period as ‘the condition of uprooted outsiders, impoverished insiders—or the descendants of either—serving persons or institutions on which they are wholly dependent’.[71] Thus, we find that in the Chola Empire, female war captives were enslaved and served as ‘reproductive pools’ for bolstering a military cadre, the *kaikkolar*s, loyal to the rulers.[72] Temple patronage in south India had also given rise to the phenomenon of female devadasis or temple-servants, which spread across India and could degenerate towards forms of harsh servitude.[73] Between the 16th and 18th century, female taken captive in war by the Rajput polity could serve as slave-performers and slave-concubines.[74]

In the 17th century, the Bengal delta became a major slave-raiding zone for the eastern kingdoms.[75] States like Assam, Manipur, Koch, Cachar and Tripura in the north-east were known to be slave-holding societies, but the major flow occurred between south-east Bengal and the Arakan (north Burma), the same passageway as that of the recent Rohingya refugee crisis. In the early 17th century, some 18,000 Bengali slaves were observed in just two small centres of the Arakan as it became a major slave-raiding state to manage the expansion of the Mrauk-U kingdom. The kingdom took the help of renegade Portuguese in these operations and also sold the slaves to Dutch-occupied Batavia (Jakarta). Growing contact with the Europeans made the Indian coasts a site of slave recruitment in the Indian Ocean world and was the precursor of the better-known mass migration of indentured labour in the 19th century, when slavery was abolished in many European colonies.

But for sheer scale and audacity, it would be the Turkish, Indian and Ethiopian slaves that would capture the imagination of west, central and South Asia. The Delhi Sultanate, under the Mamluks in the 13th century CE,